

Chabad & Jewish Federations

Changing the Dynamic

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shliach is seeking funding for a project. He presents his proposal to the staff of his local Jewish Federation, they sound enthused, and he becomes optimistic about the chances of his request being granted. He fills out the forms, provides financial statements and a project proposal, and waits for the check to arrive. Instead, he receives a rejection letter and has a hard time understanding where things went awry. This article will explore the evolution and development of the relationship between Chabad mosdos and Jewish Federations, discover the sources for rifts between the two, highlight the value of strengthening cooperation, and suggest a path forward.

FIRST, A BIT OF BACKGROUND:

The Jewish Federations of North America (JFNA) is an American Jewish umbrella organization representing 148 Jewish Federations and 300 independent Jewish communities across North America. It attempts to develop national consensus and provides support services, emergency campaigns, professional development, and conferences, including the annual General Assembly (GA). Today, collectively, Federations raise over \$1 billion a year through annual campaigns and other supplemental giving efforts, and between \$1.5-\$2 billion a year in planned gifts and endowments (much of the endowment money is donor-directed,



while only approximately 25% is discretionary). Each community conducts its own local campaign. The chapter decides how much to retain for local communal needs and then sends the bulk of the balance to JFNA in New York. The JFNA receives funds from local Federation chapters for the overseas partners of the Federation system, the Joint Distribution Committee (JDC), and the Jewish Agency for Israel (JAFI). Some Federations retain a portion to the money raised for overseas needs, funding projects in Israel or other countries directly. Nowadays, many Federations are also positioning themselves as a conduit to local philanthropists' support to special projects (known as directed giving).

Each Federation chapter is autonomous, determining its own priorities and agendas. As a continental organization, JFNA's focus is on serving, representing, and leading the local Federations. Much of the service is focused on helping the local organizations excel in their various functions. The representational role, in Washington and Yerushalayim, focuses on public policy positions that are important to the Federations and to North American Jewry generally. Leadership comes in the form of mobilizing the network during times of emergency and around issues where there is clear consensus.

JFNA's policies are set by a Board of Trustees, whose members are drawn from Federation leaders around the US and Canada. Federation chapters in cities with large Jewish communities, such as Los Angeles, Miami, Chicago, New York, Boston, and Cleveland, have the greatest influence in setting the agenda for JFNA. Midsize and smaller communities have a lesser degree of influence.

Each Federation chapter interacts with its local Chabad mosdos in a unique way. In some communities there is a strong culture of cooperation, in others the record is mixed, and in some the relationship is strained. In recent years, cooperation has been improving. A variety of factors have contributed to this, including the growing role of Chabad, a better understanding and appreciation by Federation leaders of Chabad, and an increasing number of young shluchim who have a more positive attitude towards Federations. Additionally, Federations have increased their focus on Jewish continuity as an urgent priority, which is very much in line with Chabad's principles. Still, much more needs—and can—be done. Hopefully, this article will explore the value to strengthening that cooperation, take note of the impediments that stand in the way, and suggest a path forward.

FUNDAMENTAL DIFFERENCES

Federations and Chabad have totally different organizational cultures. The Federations' decision-making process is based on developing a communal consensus through committees. Committees explore ideas, allocate funds, and set policy. Though staff may make recommendations, final decisions are made by the committee designated to that specific domain. The committees are each governed by a board of directors, hopefully representing

a cross-section of the respective community. Though the staff has great influence, the true decision-making authority lies with the board, and, in particular, the executive board.

By contrast, Chabad mosdos are entrepreneurial. At times, there may be boards, but they are appointed at the discretion of the shliach. Shluchim consult with their baalei batim but they make the decisions. At the end of the day, the shliach has the final say. Shluchim tend to be more deft, react more quickly to issues, act more decisively, and have a greater degree of creativity.

Though Federations are pluralistic, representing a variety of religious ideologies, their donor base draws most heavily from community members who are





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THE CASE FOR CHABAD ON CAMPUS

It can be an uphill battle to get Federation leadership to look beyond the way things have been done for many years and see that the dynamics of Jewish life have changed and that they stand to gain by supporting Chabad on Campus. One possible way to overcome this challenge is to frame conversations somewhat differently. Instead of asking Federation for funding for your project, tell them, “You are concerned with Jewish continuity on campus. I can help you achieve your goal.” That way, it’s not about us asking them for help, it’s about what we can do to help them. The recent study of Chabad on Campus can be a vital element to help local Federations see the value of investing with Chabad. Framing the request for specific programs, for instance Shabbat dinners, can be a way to make to support Chabad more alluring.

affiliated with the liberal denominations, or who are secular in outlook. Some Federations show respect for classical Jewish values, while others do not. Chabad is rooted halacha.

BUMPS IN THE ROAD

Federations tend to focus their funding on their historic partner agencies, namely, Jewish community centers, Hillel, Jewish Family Service Agency, and local Jewish day schools. Their hesitation to create new agencies often prevents Chabad from receiving funding. Some of the opposition to Chabad being an agency may be ideological, though some chapters simply fear stretching their limited dollars even more than they are already doing. Today, some Federations are moving away—either fully or partially—from the “agency model,” preferring to fund projects based on their respective merits.

Federations in large Jewish communities are the most challenging to work with when it comes to partnerships with Chabad. Almost all fund local Chabad schools (excluding Miami, which unfortunately does not yet), and they tend to support projects that are less parochial, such as Friendship Circle. However, when it comes to other programs, such as CTeen, Chabad on Campus, or JLI, their participation is limited, though we do see support

in some communities. The larger Federation chapters are more bureaucratic and less receptive to the idea that they gain by partnering with Chabad. In midsize and smaller communities, the cooperation is generally better. In these towns local Jewish leaders tend to know each other; there is less bureaucracy and more local cooperation on many levels.

Almost all communities appoint representatives of the local board of rabbis to the Federation Board, excluding the orthodox rabbis because they do not join this group. In our community of Orange County, a Chabad rabbi has been appointed to the Federation Board, which is something very rare.

In some communities, there is an underlying issue that needs to be confronted. Historically, Federations have a bias against Chabad and, while this is lessening, it can still be a challenge. Their leadership may not necessarily share the agenda of spirituality, Torah and mitzvos. At times, Federations reject our proposals with all kinds of reasons in attempt to hide the truth of their own bias. The only way for us to overcome this is to confront it.

STRENGTHENING COOPERATION

Some years ago, just after Hurricane Katrina, Chabad made an emergency request for funding from the JFNA. Chabad had done a stellar job in relief work. The proposal was rejected, causing the shliach who had made the funding request much anguish. He sent an email to some of the Federation staff, “You can save Jews, you can do search and rescue, you can provide food and shelter, but if you have a beard, hat, and black coat the Jewish Federations will not support you.” A senior staff person was a good friend and very sympathetic to Chabad. She circulated the email to the leadership and it became a catalyst for a vital conversation about their bias. This resulted in a change of attitude and significant funding for Chabad. While the problem of bias is becoming less, it is imperative to put it on the table and discuss it. With honest, respectful conversation it can be overcome.

At the same time, in order for Chabad to succeed with Federation, it must be a two-way street. Shluchim can’t just turn up once a year on Super Sunday. Rather, they must pursue a partnership in areas that benefit the community and do not compromise on halachic principles. This includes supporting the local campaign and encouraging the Chabad community to participate, and being an active partner in local Federation initiatives.

Many shluchim, accustomed to our entrepreneurial style of swift decisions, are frustrated with the extensive process required in order to build communal consensus. What they fail to understand is that the goal of their involvement with Federations is not just about getting funding, it’s about influencing the communal agenda. When a shliach sits on the boards and committees and is part of the process, he can shift the communal priorities to ones more reflective of Yiddishkeit.

Some shluchim have been wary that sitting on Federation

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THE REBBE ON FEDERATIONS

Time and again the Rebbe would meet with Federations leaders to encourage them to strengthen their support of Jewish education. In an unprecedented letter the Rebbe endorsed the New York Federation campaign. When the Machne Israel Development Fund was proposed, the Rebbe gave some conditions to his approval. One of them was, “on condition that it does not damage the efforts of UJA” (as the Federation campaign was known at the time).



SUCCESS IN ORANGE COUNTY

Thirty years ago, our local Federation allocated \$500 per student per year to the non-orthodox day school and just \$33 per year for students of the Chabad day school. When we requested an increase in funding, we were given all kinds of excuses as to why this could not be done—"the books are not in order, you will find the money anyway, etc." The real issue was that they were deeply prejudiced against Chabad. We confronted the issue and demanded change. It was a painful process but we overcame the issues. Today Chabad of Orange County and Federation cooperate on many levels. The Chabad school receives proper funding, as do many other Chabad projects.

When Hurricane Sandy struck, Jewish Federation and Family Services of Orange County was the only Federation outside the New York area made direct allocations to Chabad relief work in New York. (UJA in New York did provide generous funding). During the recent Gaza war, some funds from the emergency campaign were not sent to Israel via JFNA in New York, but were allocated by the local Israel Committee to projects in Israel. Forty percent of that money went to shluchim in Eretz Yisroel. Today, shluchim serve on the boards and committees, including the allocations committee. They encourage baalei batim to support Federation's work. There is a strong culture of cooperation.



committees and boards may put them into situations where they will unwittingly be supporting projects or positions that are contrary to halacha. In my over ten years on a local board I have never found myself in this position. Most Federations are involved in local day-to-day programs and do not locally vote about or discuss bigger issues, such as religious conflicts in Israel. If, however, such an issue does arise, we as shluchim need to speak up strongly with dignity for halacha. If there are projects that we feel we cannot support, it is easy to vote against them or abstain from voting. Time and again I have found a willingness of the board members to be sensitive and respectful to a Torah perspective.

Sitting on a Federation board or committee demands that we attend the meetings, be punctual, and remain involved. It is an ongoing affair. Just as we put years into changing the mindset of individual baalei batim so that they see greater value in our shlichus, spending the time entailed in being a Federation board member is an investment into changing the viewpoint of many community leaders. And, chances are that those community leaders will also elect to personally partner with Chabad. We must anticipate that change does not happen overnight, it's a slow process.

Historically, Federations and Chabad have had a mixed record of cooperation. However, with the role and influence of Chabad growing across the country, the time has come to change that dynamic. Federations in North America have a major influence on Jewish communities. They are focusing more and more on areas of building Jewish identity and share an increasingly common agenda—as well as supporters—with Chabad. Shluchim should make an active effort to become involved with their local Federation, not just to get a grant for a specific program or project but to offer ideas and support. Shluchim who have already done so have already seen success. Some Federations will unquestionably be resistant, which may seem daunting. Still, however, it is clear that by joining hands where possible, we can inspire the Federation system toward greater partnership with Chabad, as well as put the issues of Jewish education and outreach on the center of their agenda.

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OVERSEAS FUNDING

Shluchim in North American communities can help their brethren in Eretz Yisroel and across the globe. A major portion of local campaigns is dedicated to overseas funding. Most Federations direct those funds via JFNA in New York to their two prime partners, the JDC (Joint Distribution Committee) and JAFI (Jewish Agency for Israel). The JDC is based in New York and takes the lead in relief work around the world. JAFI is a partnership with the Israeli government and world Jewry. It provides important services for youth, immigrants, and those in need in Eretz Yisroel. Additionally, and funds projects around the world to bolster Jewish identity.

Shluchim in cooperation with local Jewish leaders can encourage JFNA, the JDC, and JAFI to fund Chabad projects globally. There are already areas of cooperation in the FSU, where in some communities the JDC and Chabad jointly operate food kitchens and other services. JAFI, too, can be encouraged to partner in Jewish identity projects as well as Chabad's programs in Eretz Yisroel. Shluchim outside of North America can also encourage groups like the United Israel Appeal in Australia, Keren Hayesod in South Africa, and other national fundraising entities to consider Chabad as a partner in Eretz Yisroel and globally.

Some Federations make direct grants to organizations in Eretz Yisroel, at times in partnership with specific communities. In Charlotte, North Carolina, local shluchim helped create a partnership with Chabad in Hadera, enabling them to receive funding for their soup kitchen from the Charlotte Federation. Local shluchim need to investigate the funding priorities of their communities and attempt to find Chabad mosdos in Eretz Yisroel or overseas that can help the local Federation meet its funding goals. 



KEY POINTS to Remember



CHABAD is entrepreneurial, FEDERATIONS ARE consensus driven.



Though staff have INFLUENCE, the COMMITTEES have the FINAL word.



It's not just about funding, but building a relationship and MOLDING COMMUNITY PRIORITIES.



FEDERATIONS MOVE VERY SLOWLY. We need to understand that change can take years.



THEY BENEFIT BY SUPPORTING CHABAD: we are building Yiddishkeit and it spills over to all aspects of the community.



Many Federations leaders and staff have had positive interactions with Chabad. TODAY THEY ARE MORE OPEN TO US.



NEVER COMPROMISE YOUR PRINCIPLES.



When you encounter bias against Chabad, confront it directly with respect—ONLY THEN WILL YOU OVERCOME IT.